



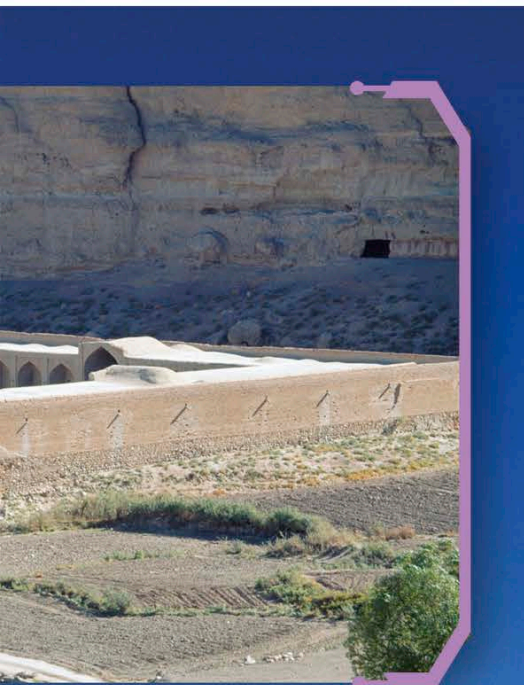
The Silk Road

This Spanish map shows the areas connected by the Silk Road, the network of trade routes between China and Europe. The mapmakers may have used the reports of traders such as Marco Polo to help them complete their work.

Beijing in China is described on the map as the city of the great Khan.

A dangerous journey

Travelers along the Silk Road often joined large groups called caravans. Together, these traders were better able to survive extreme desert conditions and protect themselves from bandit attacks.



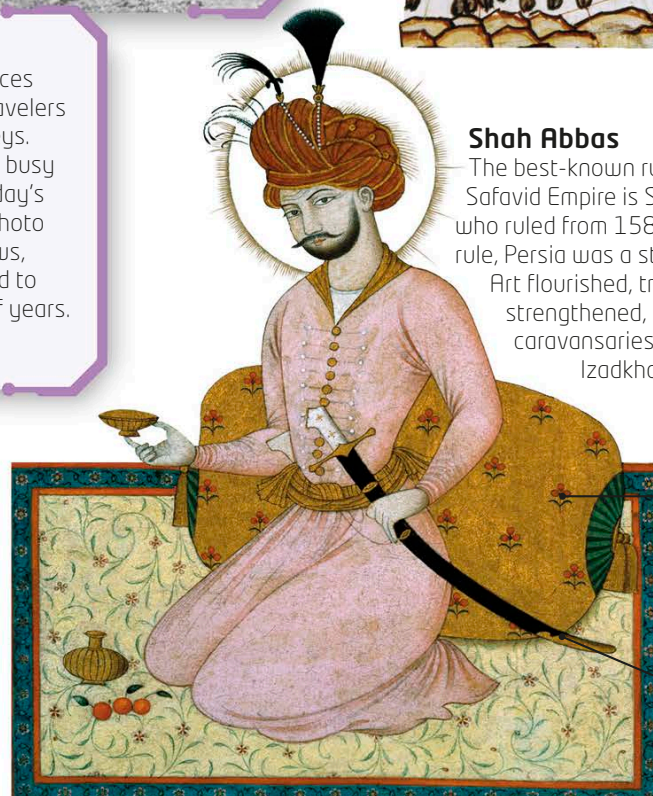
Rest stops

Caravansaries were places where long-distance travelers could break their journeys. They were built next to busy trade routes, around a day's journey apart. As this photo from around 1898 shows, caravansaries continued to be used for hundreds of years.



Shah Abbas

The best-known ruler of the Persian Safavid Empire is Shah Abbas the Great, who ruled from 1588 to 1629. Under his rule, Persia was a strong military empire. Art flourished, trade links were strengthened, and many caravansaries, including Izadkhaht, were built.



Rich silks would have been imported from China.

This type of curved sword is called a scimitar.



Niches provided shade from the desert sun.